

5.6 Instant Messengers

Ever since they burst onto the scene, Instant Messengers (or IMs) have changed the way we communicate. Their cost-effectiveness meant that distance no longer played a part in immediate communication.

Before IMs, one either had to make expensive ISD calls or send e-mails (even snail mail at times). These were either too expensive or too time consuming (by today's standards).

With IMs, one can chat in real-time with anyone who has an Internet connection. With VoIP technology finally taking off at a mass level in the last few years, there is also the added incentive of voice chat.

What's more, all these can easily be easily integrated with video chat. All this takes place in real-time, and this means the fantasies of the '80s are becoming reality. This is now the most preferred way of communication for the younger demographic. Such has been the impact of IMs that there is a growing trend of building up of virtual communities whose only presence is online. With technological innovations coming in every day, IM chat technology not only provides instant real-time communication but also adds colour and personality, which many prefer over traditional forms of communication. Today, IMs comes with variety of features, and here's a look at some of the best.

MSN Messenger 7.0

One of the oldest—and arguably the best—IM clients around, MSN Messenger has been one of the best Microsoft products yet. It has almost all the features anyone would want for chatting and exchanging files.

A brilliant interface with a customisable appearance gives users the feel of 'being there'. Communication is reliable—there is hardly any loss of chat text. Even messages that do not make it to the recipients are returned to the sender with a notice.